R 80-06

PROFICIENCY TESTING AND/OR INTERLABORATORY COMPARISON OTHER THAN PROFICIENCY TESTING REQUIREMENTS FOR TESTING, MEDICAL LABORATORIES AND BLOOD TRANSFUSION SERVICES

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Date of Approval:	2025-05-06	
Date of Implementation:	2025-05-12	

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1. Introduction

This document outlines the requirements and processes for SANAS to assess the participation of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) in Proficiency Testing (PT) and/or Interlaboratory Comparisons (ILC) other than PT (herein referred to as PT/ILC), as part of the accreditation process.

It is aligned with the ILAC-P9:01/2024 and the current versions of ISO/IEC 17025, ISO 15189 and ISO/IEC 17011. The review of performance in PT and ILCs is considered as an assessment technique, and participation in PT/ILC, organised by competent providers is, for an accredited CAB, an integral part of the monitoring of the validity of its results.

2. Purpose and Scope

The purpose of this document is to define the requirements for the participation of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) in PT/ILC, which form part of the accreditation criteria.

It also guides SANAS on the use and assessment of PT/ILC in the accreditation process and helps harmonize practices in accordance with international mutual recognition arrangement (MRA).

This document applies to all applicant or accredited CABs that perform testing activities, i.e.: testing and medical laboratories and blood transfusion services (excluding donor clinics).

3. References and Definitions

3.1 References

SANAS PM 01	SANAS Policy Manual
SANAS A 01	References, Acronyms and Definitions
ISO/IEC 17011	Conformity Assessment – General Requirements for Accreditation Bodies Accrediting Conformity Assessment Bodies.
ISO/IEC 17025	General Requirements for the Competence of Testing and Calibration Laboratories.
ISO/IEC 17043	Conformity assessment – General requirements for Proficiency Testing
ISO 15189	Medical laboratories – Requirements for quality and competence
	Standards of Practice for Blood Transfusion in South Africa
ILAC-P9:01/2024	ILAC Policy for Participation in Proficiency Testing Activities.
	AFRAC GD004 Guidance for assessing the appropriateness of few participants in an interlaboratory comparison programme
AFRAC GD004	Guidance for assessing the appropriateness of few participants in an interlaboratory comparison programme
ISO 13528	Statistical methods for use in proficiency testing by interlaboratory comparison.
EA-4/18	Guidance on the level and frequency of proficiency testing participation

3.2 Definitions

3.2.1 **Assigned value**:
Value attributed to a particular property of a proficiency test item (ISO/IEC 17043: 3.1)
Note: for the purpose of this document, this is the property value of the ILC test item.

3.2.2 **Interlaboratory Comparison (ILC)**:
Design, performance and evaluation of measurements or tests on the same or similar items by two or more laboratories in accordance with predetermined conditions. (ISO/IEC 17043:2023, 3.4).

3.2.3 **ILC organiser** / **PT Provider**:
The laboratory which takes responsibility for the development and operation of the PT/ILC. Adapted from ISO/IEC 17043: 3.9

3.2.4 **ILC Test Item**:
Sample, product, artefact, reference material, piece of equipment, measurement standard, data set or other information used for proficiency testing (Adapted from ISO/IEC 17043: 3.8). Note: For the purpose of this document, the ILC test item can be regarded equivalent to the proficiency test item.

3.2.5 **Proficiency Testing (PT):**
Evaluation of participant performance against pre-established criteria by means of interlaboratory comparisons. (ISO/IEC 17043:2023, 3.7).
Note: In ISO 15189:2022, the term PT is replaced by EQA (external quality assessment).
Note: In this document, all reference to PT also includes ILC other than PT.

3.2.6 **PT Participant:**
A person or CAB that undertakes activities related to PT/ILC and submits their results for evaluation by the PT/ILC provider or organiser.

3.2.7 **PT Participation Plan** (herein referred to as a **PT Plan**)**:**
A structured documented strategy outlining how a CAB will participate in appropriate PTand/or ILC programs in a defined period.

3.2.8 **PT Provider Plan:**
A proficiency testing provider plan is a structured outline or strategy developed by organizations offering proficiency testing services.

3.2.9 **Proficiency Testing Scheme:**
Proficiency testing designed and operated in one or more rounds for a specific area of testing, measurement, calibration or inspection**.**

3.2.10 **External quality assessment (EQA):**
Evaluation of participant performance against pre-established criteria by means of interlaboratory comparisons (ISO 15189:2022, 3.10).

3.2.11 **Small ILC:**
An interlaboratory comparison organised by, and among seven or less laboratories.
Note: Small ILC is considered an alternative method to PT/ILC.

3.2.12 **Standard deviation for proficiency assessment (SDPA, σPT):**
Measure of dispersion used in the evaluation of results of proficiency testing, based on the available information (ISO/IEC 17043: 3.13)

3.2.13 **Frequency of participation:**
The number of proficiency tests per unit of time, in which a CAB participates for an activity as specified in their scope of accreditation.

3.2.14 **Level of participation:**
The number of specific activities that an organisation identifies within its scope of accreditation, and therefore the number of specific proficiency tests that should be considered for participation.

4. General Requirements for the assessment of PT and/or ILCs other than PT

4.1 The conformity assessment standards used for accrediting CABs, listed below, specify the need for participation in PT and/or ILCs other than PT:

i) ISO/IEC 17025:2017, clause 7.7.2, requires that the laboratory monitors its performance by comparison with results of other laboratories, through participation in PT and/or ILCs other than PT, where available and appropriate;

ii) ISO 15189:2022, clause 7.3.7.3, requires that the laboratory participates in an EQA program appropriate to the examination and interpretation of examination results, including POCT (Point of care testing) examination methods. When an EQA programme is either not available, or not considered suitable, the laboratory shall use alternative methodologies to monitor examination method performance, including ILCs other than PT.

Taking into consideration the outcome of a CAB's risk assessment, participation in PT/ILC is considered as mandatory when available, appropriate and deemed necessary.

An applicant or accredited CAB is therefore required to plan and monitor its participation in PT/ILC. Based on ISO/IEC 17025:2017, clause 8.5 and ISO 15189:2022, clauses 8.5 and 7.3.7.3, the planning is to take into account the risks and opportunities of the laboratory activity. This includes an evaluation of the level and frequency of participation in PT/ILC.

4.2 It should be emphasised that participation in ILCs other than PT should only be envisaged when PTs are not available, and/or appropriate.

A PT is considered **available and/or appropriate**, if it is:

i) Offered by PT provider, accredited to ISO/IEC 17043:2023 by SANAS or another Accreditation Body (AB) signatory of the ILAC MRA for PT providers;

ii) Offered by a PT provider, accredited to ISO/IEC 17043:2023 by an applicant AB or an AB that is not a signatory of the ILAC MRA for PT providers;

iii) Organised by or participated in accordance with the relevant requirements of ISO/IEC 17043:2023, to determine the performance of accredited CABs by comparison with results of other laboratories.

For the last 2 bullet points above, there is no formal recognition of competence, in terms of ILAC MRA, of the PT and/or ILC provider.

Note: *AFRAC GD004 should be used to assess the validity of the two last bullet points in regard to meeting the relevant requirements of ISO/IEC 17043:2023.*

4.3 Accredited laboratories use the results of PT/ILC to identify opportunities for improvement and shall implement any necessary actions and shall ensure, where necessary, that appropriate root cause analysis, corrective actions and preventative actions are carried out.

5. Requirements for the PT Plan

5.1 All applicant and accredited CABs shall develop a **PT Plan** that outlines their participation in appropriate PT/ILC.

5.2 The PT Plan shall cover all activities listed on the CAB's proposed scope of accreditation / accredited scope, including specific tests or methods where these have been separately

listed, covering a large portion of their proposed range and at a consummate level of uncertainty.

5.3 The Plan must be based on a **risk assessment** conducted by the CAB to determine the appropriate level and frequency of participation. The CAB must consider the potential risks and impacts of its activities on the validity of results.

5.4 All accredited CABs shall have available a PT / ILC plan for at least 2 accreditation cycles, i.e. the participation plan for the past accreditation cycle (where practical) and the plan for the current accreditation cycle. All accredited parameters shall be subject to PT/ILC in a period not exceeding 1 accreditation cycle.

Note: The frequency and extent of participation shall be justified by the CAB to SANAS for each accredited method and shall be included in the plan.

5.5 All accredited CABs should preferably participate in proficiency testing schemes that have been independently shown to comply with the requirements of ISO/IEC 17043. Participation in other unaccredited schemes is acceptable until such time that there are sufficient accredited schemes in the various disciplines. The CAB shall satisfy itself on the competence of the PT providers whose schemes it voluntarily participates in.

5.6 SANAS accredited PT Providers are available on the SANAS website. For any other PT participation, refer to clause 4.2 (ii and iii).

5.7 CABs can from time to time be invited to participate in international proficiency testing schemes. Such participation is usually above and beyond that as required by SANAS and is at the discretion of the CAB and / or SANAS.

5.8 The CAB **shall** review their own performance, evaluate possible trends and investigate all measurement results that fail to meet the minimum acceptance criteria, including where there is evidence of consistent poor performance, and record the root cause analysis conducted and all corrective and preventative action(s) taken.

5.9 The PT plan shall be addressed in the CAB's documented management system, and the plan shall be subject to review in response to changes in staff, methodology or instrumentation, revision and approval as described.

5.10 The CAB's PT Plan **shall** be submitted to SANAS as part of the application documents, for initial, surveillance assessment and re-assessment.

5.11 The CAB's PT Plan **shall** be available for evaluation during the assessment of the CAB; additionally SANAS may request that a copy of the plan be submitted for evaluation at any time. The CAB **shall** ensure that the plan is maintained and kept current.

5.12 The CAB's PT plan shall, as a minimum, include the following points:

- A breakdown of the parameters for which PT is conducted;
- Proficiency testing type (Inter-laboratory comparison; Intra-laboratory comparison; Use of a Reference material, PT scheme);
- Identification and number of participants, and/or potential participants for ILC;
- The name/s and or identification of the PT/ILC schemes which the CAB intends to participate;
- Name and make of reference material used;
- The proposed measurement artefact or instrument;
- The measurement parameters, including range and measurement points;
- How the reference or consensus value is to be established;
- The minimum acceptance criteria for satisfactory participation;

- How the uncertainty of the reference value or the uncertainty of the inter-laboratory comparison is to be established;
- Responsibility for issue of the PT / ILC report, who shall be a competent PT provider, and who will act as the referee in the event there are only 2 participants and there is a disagreement in the results;
- Where applicable, the typical ranges that cover the scope of accreditation, particularly where measurements at extremities may pose specific measurement challenges;
- Level and Frequency of participation per time period justified by the CAB.

Note 1: *Any alternative approaches to PT/ILC shall be indicated in the CABs PT Plan.*

Note 2: *Where any information above cannot be confirmed during the planning stage, the exclusion must be justified.*

It is accepted that the detail in the PT plan will be more comprehensive for the current and following year, than activity scheduled for subsequent years.

6. Alternative approaches to PT and/or ILCs other than PT

6.1 Absence of available or appropriate PT/ILC:

Where no formal PT/ILC is available or appropriate for a specific scope, the CAB shall indicate other interlaboratory activities in which they intend to participate to ensure the validity of its results. These may include activities such as intra-laboratory comparisons, the use of reference materials or replicate tests using the same or different methods.

6.2 Justification for Alternative Methods

A CAB must justify the use of alternative approaches to the relevant Accreditation Manager (AM) in writing, when there are no available and appropriate PT/ILC to cover the applicant or accredited scope.

The relevant AM shall evaluate the alternate methodologies through consultation with Technical Assessor(s) and Expert(s) where required and a written approval with defined validity period will be provided to the CAB.

The onus is on the CAB to provide the details of the plan and its justification thereof and obtain written approval from SANAS. Such alternatives must still comply with the reporting requirements in clause 7.

6.3 Participation in small ILC

Should the CAB participate in small ILC, the operation of the ILC shall comply with the relevant requirements of ISO/IEC 17043. Refer to AFRAC GD004.

7. Requirements for the PT Provider's Plan and Report

7.1 The PT Provider's Plan, where applicable, shall be in accordance ISO/IEC 17043:2023, clause 7.2.1.3.

7.2 For small ILC, the PT Provider Plan shall include:

- Main contact person;
- If organised jointly, the persons or laboratories involved;

- The measurand or characteristic to be determined;
- Requirements (production, homogeneity, stability) for the ILC test item;
- Information on the use and preparation of the ILC test item (description of the preparation, if applicable);
- Timeframe of the scheme;
- Information on the method(s) to be used;
- Description of the method for the evaluation of the comparability of the results, statistical analysis, if applicable, and the criteria used for the evaluation of performance; and
- Description of the reporting format for the participants and from the organiser.

7.3 The PT Scheme / ILC reports **shall** be clear and comprehensive and include at least the following minimum information:

- A unique report number, and identification of the PT or ILC activity;
- Identification of the participants;
- Measurement protocol (ISO/IEC 17043:2023, clause 7.1.2);
- Identification of the measurement standard or Artefact;
- Measurement results;
- The reference value/s and how these were established;
- Evaluation of the measurement results;
- An indication of the performance of individual participants;
- Minimum acceptance criteria;
- Date of issue;
- Conclusion.

7.4 For small ILC, the ILC organiser shall develop a report which, in addition to the information in clause 7.2, shall also include:

- Contact person;
- Persons or laboratories involved in the organisation of the small ILC;
- Identification of the small ILC scheme;
- Description of the small ILC test item;
- Comparability of the participants results and/or participants performance; and
- Comments and recommendations based on the outcome of the small ILC scheme.

7.5 The CAB **shall** make available to the assessment team all PT/ILC plans and reports provided by the PT provider / ILC organiser.

8. Requirements for the Assessment of the PT Plan and Performance

8.1 SANAS shall assess the PT Plan to ensure that there is a representative and satisfactory participation in PT/ILC activities regarding an applicant scope before granting accreditation.

8.2 SANAS shall ensure that the PT Plan foresees a representative participation in PT/ILC activities regarding any accreditation scope.

8.3 SANAS shall assess the suitability of the “frequency” of participation of the CAB, based on the level of risk, and the minimum frequency of participation for each area of technical competence as set by the CAB.

8.4 SANAS shall assess the justifications and appropriateness of the CAB’s alternative approaches when there are no available and appropriate PT/ILC to cover the applicant or accredited scope. SANAS shall verify that the alternative approach implemented by the CAB ensures the validity of the results.

8.5 Where satisfactory performance is not achieved, the evidence of implementation of prompt and appropriate corrective actions will be evaluated during the assessment and taken into consideration during the decision making process.

9. Processes for the Assessment of PT and/or ILCs other than PT

9.1 Assessment of participation and performance

How SANAS takes into consideration PT/ILC participation and performance (in particular when persistent poor performance is identified); Note: This includes PT/ILC that have been mandated, for example by a regulator, an industry or professional sector:

i) Evaluate the Root Cause of Poor Performance:

- **SANAS will assess** evidence of the CABs participation in PT and/or ILCs. If poor performance is identified, the CAB's must provide evidence that an internal investigation to determine the root causes has been conducted.

- **Risk Analysis**: SANAS will assess whether the poor performance of the CAB has any significant risk to the validity of the results. This analysis should consider the potential impact on the accuracy of the CAB's results and its overall performance within its scope of accreditation.

ii) Verification of Corrective Actions:

- **Corrective Action Plans**: SANAS must assess whether the CAB implements prompt and appropriate corrective actions to address the identified root causes of poor performance. The CAB should document these actions, which may include revising procedures, retraining staff, recalibrating equipment, or implementing improved monitoring mechanisms.

- **Follow-Up on Corrective Actions**: After corrective actions have been implemented, the SANAS should monitor the CAB's performance in subsequent PTs or ILCs. This may be done by reviewing new results and verifying if improvements have been made. If persistent poor performance continues, further intervention may be necessary.

iii) Review the CAB's PT Plan:

- **Adequacy of the PT Plan**: SANAS will review the CAB's PT Plan to assess whether the scope, frequency, and type of PTs or ILCs are adequate and suitable for the CAB's scope of activities. If the CAB's plan does not align with its scope of accreditation, then SANAS will require the CAB to adjust its plan.

- **Technical Competence**: SANAS will evaluate whether the CAB has the necessary technical competence to interpret and perform the tasks associated with the PTs and ILCs in question. This may involve reviewing the qualifications and experience of technical staff, as well as ensuring the CAB has access to appropriate resources (e.g., reference materials, instruments).

iv) Actions to Improve Performance:

- **SANAS will assess** the actions taken by the CAB to improve its performance in PT and/or ILCs.

- **Alternative Measures**: If PTs and ILCs continue to be unavailable or unsuitable, SANAS will assess the CAB's alternative approaches to ensure the validity of its results.

v) Consideration of Regulatory or Industry Requirements:

- **External Mandates**: In cases where the PT and/or ILC participation is mandated by a regulator, industry, or professional body, SANAS will consider the impact of persistent poor performance on the CAB's ability to meet such requirements.

vi) Corrective Action Follow-Up and Continuous Monitoring:

- **Ongoing Monitoring**: After any corrective actions are taken, SANAS will assess how a CAB continues to monitor their own performance, including any actions taken for poor performance during follow-up assessments.

- **Suspension or Withdrawal of Accreditation**: In cases where a CAB's performance continues to be unsatisfactory, despite corrective actions and attempts to improve, SANAS may need to take more severe actions, which may lead to suspension or withdrawal of the CAB's accreditation.

9.2 Actions when PT Plans are inadequate:

How SANAS deals with the situation where the CAB's PT Plan is considered not suitable in relation to the scope of accreditation:

- If SANAS determines that a CAB's PT Plan is unsuitable or insufficient for its scope of accreditation, SANAS shall take appropriate action, which may include:
  - Requiring a revision of the Plan;
  - Raising a non-conformance, for the CAB to appropriately address;
  - Suspending, reducing or withdrawing the CABs scope of accreditation if the matter cannot be resolved.

9.3 Planning of Assessments

How SANAS takes into account a CAB's PT/ILC performance, to plan the assessments:

- SANAS may consider increasing the frequency of assessments in circumstances where the CAB's PT/ILC participation and/or performance is poor.
- SANAS may consider regular assessment of the PT/ILC participation through document review.

9.4 Competence of PT providers

How SANAS ensures that the laboratories have appropriate evidence of the competence of the PT provider or the organisation providing ILCs (Refer to clause 4.2).

- SANAS must verify that the PT provider or organization facilitating ILCs has the appropriate competence and/or accreditation. This can be done by verifying the PT provider's accreditation status or reviewing evidence demonstrating their competence.

Note: Additional guidance on the evaluation of measurement results, and preparation of PT / ILC scheme reports is available in ISO/IEC 17043.

APPENDIX A (Informative): Guidance on the level and frequency of PT participation

This guidance aims to promote harmonisation on how the level and frequency of participation in PT is assessed during the accreditation process and to assist CABs in determining their own levels and frequency of participation.

A: General aspects

The following aspects are considered by SANAS when determining the suitability of CAB's PT Plan. That is, its "level" and "frequency" of participation in PT in relation to the activities, performed under its accreditation scope / scope of accreditation applied for:

(1) The CAB should define its level and frequency of participation after careful analysis of its other quality assurance (QA) measures for ensuring the validity of results. The level and frequency of participation should depend on the nature and complexity of measurements, and the extent to which other measures have been taken into account. QA measures can include, but are not limited to:

- Regular use of certified reference materials and/or reference materials.
- Comparison of analysis by independent techniques.
- Participation in ILCs for method development/validation and/or reference material characterisation studies.
- Use of internal quality control (IQC) measures.
- Other inter/intra – CAB comparisons e.g. analysis on blind samples within the CAB.
- Robustness of the metrological traceability chain. (Are instruments calibrated under the same conditions as routinely used versus assumptions on e.g. influence factors or secondary parameters)

Other types of measures for ensuring validity of results include, but are not limited to those listed in ISO/IEC 17025:2017, clause 7.7.

(2) The level of risk presented by the CAB, the sector in which it operates or the methodology it is using. This can be determined, for example, by considering:

- Number and frequency of activities undertaken;
- Turnover of technical staff;
- Experience and knowledge of technical staff;
- Source of metrological traceability (e.g. availability of reference materials, national measurement standards, etc.);
- Known stability/instability of the test or measurement technique;
- Stability of the analyte and matrix, and the impact of storage and transportation;
- Significance and final use of test data (e.g. laboratories represent areas requiring a high level of assurance);
- Level of risk posed by Biohazardous PT items used and the containment precautions required;
- Number of different calibration intervals;
- Complexity and robustness of the methodology;
- When statements of conformity are required and changes in related specifications are made;
- Risks and opportunities associated with the CAB activities, in particular those that will prevent, or reduce, undesired impacts and potential failures in the CAB activities and achieve improvement;
- Extent of validation and/or verification.

(3) Different types of ILCs that can be used by laboratories and that should be accepted by SANAS as alternatives to PTs, include:

- ILC organised by a sufficient number of laboratories as a once-off or continual exercise;

- Organisation of small interCAB comparisons.

Note: CABs that organise a small ILC among themselves should apply the relevant requirements of ISO/IEC 17043:2023, if the results and evaluation of performance are to be used as a tool to monitor and demonstrate the validity of their results. Refer to AFRAC GD004**.**

(4) It should be recognised that there are sectors where participation in PT may be difficult, due to the technical characteristics of the test or measurement, the lack of PT schemes, the low number of existing CABs in the sector, etc. For some fields PT may only be possible or economically feasible for parts of the activities undertaken. In these areas the suitability of other measures is paramount.

(5) Any requirements for frequency and type of PT participation from other sources, e.g. legislation, customers, etc.

B: Level and frequency of participation

The first step for laboratories is to consider the scope of accreditation and the activities for which they are accredited.

Ideally, an accredited CAB would participate in a specific PT for every measurement technique it uses and for every characteristic (component, parameter) measured in every product. However, it is acknowledged that this is not always feasible, both logistically and economically. Therefore, the CAB must identify groups of areas of technical competence (defined by a minimum of one measurement technique, characteristic and product which are related). The performance obtained in the PT for one combination within a defined area can be directly correlated to the other combinations of test or measurement techniques, characteristics and products contained within the same area of technical competence.

An area of technical competence, as mentioned above, may contain more than one measurement technique, characteristic or product as long as equivalence and comparability can be demonstrated. The first consideration for an accredited CAB, when determining an area of technical competence, is that it should generally not contain different technical competences. Different technical competences can usually be identified by the need for different qualifications, training, and use of different equipment, knowledge, or experience.

When determining an area of technical competence, it may be helpful to consider a stepwise approach working up from the measurement technique through characteristics to products. This is because it is more likely that there will be several products and/or characteristics associated with one measurement technique within a given area than vice versa:

(i) With reference to the measurement technique: It is possible but not common to include different measurement techniques in the same area of technical competence;

(ii) With reference to the characteristic to be measured, determined or identified: It may be possible to include more than one characteristic in the same area of technical competence;

(iii) With reference to products to be tested: It may be possible to include different products in the same area of technical competence provided that the matrices, objects or materials included, are of equivalent nature.

When a CAB determines that more than one measurement technique, characteristic or product is classified within the same area of technical competence, SANAS will evaluate whether the CAB can justify and demonstrate equivalence. This can usually be done by, for example:

- The method validation data, or;
- Use of the same test method

Once the CAB has defined its areas of technical competence, the “level of participation” can be deemed to have been defined. SANAS will also evaluate the suitability of the “frequency” of participation of the CAB, based on the level of risk, and should expect a minimum frequency of participation for each area of technical competence to be set by the CAB.

It should also be considered that according to ISO/IEC 17025:2017 (7.7.1 and 7.7.2) the CAB shall have a procedure for monitoring the validity of results and that these are to be planned. Therefore, once

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the “level” and “frequency” of participation have been established, the CAB will be able to establish their PT plan. The extent and content of this plan will depend upon the circumstances and scope of the individual CAB. This should form part of the CAB’s overall quality control (QC) strategy.

The establishment of areas of technical competence may be different for every CAB. For this reason, laboratories must be able to justify the technical arguments that have led to their decision on the “defined areas” “level” and “frequency” of participation in PT. Laboratories should document this justification.

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ADDENDUM 1: AMENDMENT RECORD

Proposed By:	Section	Change
QM and AMs	All	Entire re-write and alignment to ILAC P9